



Diversity management and organizational change

What can institutional theory contribute to our understanding of the lack of radical change?

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Abstract

Purpose – Set against a background of numerous institutionally funded programmes with a focus on gender mainstreaming, the purpose of this paper is to draw on institutional theory as an alternative lens to explain why such programmes often fail to achieve the desired outcomes.

Design/methodology/approach – The paper is based on a case of a European Social Fund EQUAL Programme aimed at enhancing employment opportunities for women in Information Technology, Electronics and Communication and related sectors. The paper focuses on the partnership working aspect, which is a fundamental mobilizing structure of European Commission programmes. Insights into the experiences of partnership working were gathered from interviews with 18, out of the 24 participating partners, on this specific programme.

Findings – Tensions with partnership working are exposed and discussed: frustration with intra-organizational collaborative working and structures and outputs that promote a mimetic approach to change, legitimized through the symbolic use of “best practice”; findings more consistent with “institutional isomorphism”, as opposed to “institutional innovation”.

Social implications – Given that partnership working remains a key mobilizing structure of gender mainstreaming programmes, both within Europe and in other contexts, the paper concludes with recommendations aimed at those responsible for commissioning and overseeing such programmes.

Originality/value – This paper draws on institutional theory as an alternative lens to examine and explain why gender mainstreaming programmes do not always achieve the intended outcomes. To date, as others acknowledge, there has been limited work that has applied organizational theory to this problem.

Keywords Institutional theory, Organizational change, Partnership working, Diversity management
Paper type Research paper

Introduction: the wider context for gender diversity change programmes

Faced with talent shortages in the expanding knowledge economy there has been a continuing discourse about the business benefits of building a diverse workforce, with a particular focus on gender diversity (DTI, 2005; European Commission, 2006a; Evans, 2012; Jonsen *et al.*, 2013). This discourse has been accompanied by a plethora of institutionally funded initiatives aimed at addressing gender inequalities and promoting gender mainstreaming in science and technology workplaces. Within Europe, the European Commission (EC) set a budget of 50 billion for the latest and final Framework Programme for Research and Technological Development (FP7); many of these funded projects align with the European Union's commitment to gender mainstreaming (European Commission, 2010). Yet despite this significant and continuing investment, “[...] this situation is not self-rectifying [...] talents are poorly utilized due to continued career development constraints and bias” (European Commission, 2012, p. 9).

Against this context, this paper draws on institutional theory (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983; Zucker, 1987; Greenwood and Hinings, 1996) as an alternative analytical lens to explain why institutionally funded diversity management programmes, aimed



at gender mainstreaming, do not appear to achieve the desired outcomes; outcomes consistent with a radical change agenda (Jewson and Mason, 1986; Pollack and Hafner-Burton, 2000; Jonsen *et al.*, 2013). Institutional theory would seem an opposite lens to investigate this phenomenon, since it draws attention to the role that social forces play in influencing organizational actions, including how organizations seek and gain legitimacy (Harcourt *et al.*, 2005; Jain *et al.*, 2012). Moreover as a theory of organizational analysis, institutional theory offers a lens to explain tensions between structure and agency (Yang and Konrad, 2011), and the political nature of organizational decision making (Pettigrew, 1973; Ferner *et al.*, 2005).

The main focus is an exploration of a specific aspect of the structural elements of EC-funded programmes, partnership working. Partnership working has been, and remains, a fundamental mobilizing structure of EC-funded programmes (Pollack and Hafner-Burton, 2000; European Commission, 2014). It is assumed that partnership working brings “collaborative advantage” (Huxham and Macdonald, 1992 cited in Dudau and McAllister, 2010), enabling social actors engaged in these types of programmes to address tensions such as fragmentation of policies, infrastructure and practice (European Commission, 2012). The paper draws on two data sources. First EC reports that set out the broader rationale and expected outcomes of gender mainstreaming programmes. Second, findings from an evaluation of a specific programme aimed at increasing women’s employment opportunities within the Information Technology, Electronics and Communication (ITEC) sector, funded through the EC’s European Social Fund (ESF) EQUAL initiative; one of a series of programmes linked to the European Union’s gender mainstreaming agenda.

The rest of this paper is structured as follows. First, I elaborate on the situation with women’s employment within the ITEC sector and why it is perceived to be a continuing problem. Second, I provide a rationale for drawing on institutional theory as an analytical lens to explain why programmes with a gender mainstreaming focus, do not necessarily achieve the intended outcomes. Third, I provide an overview of a specific ESF EQUAL Programme, situating this within a broader context of EC-funded gender mainstreaming programmes, before setting out and analysing the experiences of partnership working on this specific programme. Finally in the concluding section, I discuss how institutional theory extends our thinking on the reasons why diversity management programmes (aimed at gender mainstreaming) do not necessarily result in outcomes consistent with a radical change approach, followed by practical recommendations for those who commission and retain oversight of these types of programmes.

Gender mainstreaming initiatives within the competitive ITEC sector: practitioner vs theoretical explanations

Changes in the global ICT business sector, which Loogma (2004) refer to as the “new service sector”, have created new opportunities and challenges for employers and indeed individuals seeking employment in this sector. Structural changes, such as the need for multi-functional and multi-skilled project teams, together with an emphasis on maintaining closer contact with clients (Glover and Guerrier, 2010), have surfaced debates about the type of skills required to perform effectively in these environments. A recurring theme is the increasing emphasis on the importance of “hybrid skills”; a combination of technical and “soft” skills that employers claim they need (Grugulis, 2007; Glover and Guerrier, 2010). In environments that require a “high touch” client experience, hybrid workers are often constructed as ideal workers. Given the

assumption that women are naturally endowed with “soft” skills it is perhaps not surprising that organizations appear to want to create more opportunities for them (Guerrier *et al.*, 2009; Glover and Guerrier, 2010).

In contexts experiencing talent shortages a diversity management approach, underpinned by business case rationale, is positioned as a key lever for mobilizing action aimed at addressing gender imbalances in the workplace (Özbilgin and Tatli, 2008; Jonsen *et al.*, 2013; Rubery and Rafferty, 2013). Organizations in all sectors, and the ICT sector is no exception, have been quick to adopt business case arguments to justify if and when to initiate change consistent with a diversity management approach (Guerrier and Wilson, 2011; Evans, 2012). Yet the business case for diversity has been contested on a number of grounds. The instrumentalist contingent nature of business arguments has widely criticized (Noon, 2007; Bleijenbergh *et al.*, 2010; Jonsen *et al.*, 2013; Rubery and Rafferty, 2013). Whilst business case arguments can have short-term effects on employment rates for women, statistics provided by the EC (2012, p. 5) indicate that progress on the gender mainstreaming agenda is slow, especially women’s employment in “Business Industries”.

Despite the criticism of business case arguments, businesses, government departments and organizations such as the EC, continue to draw on these to legitimize the way in which initiatives aimed at a gender mainstreaming agenda are funded. How then might we account for such behavior? It is this question I address next, through the lens of institutional theory. Institutional theory is considered a robust theory that seeks to expose and explain organizational behavior in a given context (see DiMaggio and Powell, 1983; Zucker, 1987; Greenwood and Hinings, 1996). Although not a theory of organizational change as such, institutional theory provides an alternative lens through which to understand the complexities of organizational decision making and accompanying actions; “[...] it [institutional theory] taps into the taken-for-granted assumptions at the core of social action” (Zucker, 1987, p. 443). When applied to an analysis of organizational change, institutional theory can help surface and explain why organizations operating within the same context adopt practices, that fall into the normative, instrumental, as opposed radical, end of the change continuum (Zucker, 1987; Greenwood and Hinings, 1996; Ferner *et al.*, 2005). Whilst there is not scope within this paper to include an extensive review of organizational change models, I briefly summarize here key differences between normative and radical change, as it relates to the area of gender mainstreaming. Linstead *et al.* (2005) suggest that traditional change models, such as Lewin’s (1947) unfreezing-change-refreezing model, position change as a rationale and logical process that does not reflect the complexities of organizational change, or indeed how organizational change is itself a gendered concept. Change implemented through this conceptual lens is thus unlikely to result in an in-depth review of structures and practices that may get in the way of achieving diversity goals, but instead seeks more instrumental quick win solutions. A radical change approach, on the other hand, includes change that affects and/or disrupts all parts of the organization (Yang and Konrad, 2011), through exploring and implementing sustainable longer-term solutions through the adoption of multi-dimensional performance goals (Jonsen *et al.*, 2013). Drawing on the work of Martin and Meyerson (2008), Jonsen *et al.*, (2013, p. 273) suggest that one of the reasons for a lack of radical change, is that organizations become “trapped in incrementalism and institutional interlocks”, where change(s) in one institutional context can then undermine that in others.

Initial proponents of institutional theory emphasized three inter-related aspects of organizational behavior (Scott, 1987). First, organizational behavior emanates from the

values and beliefs in a specific context. Second, similar experiences and pressures result in organizations adopting similar forms, or archetypes. Third, and related to the second aspect, institutional actors “[...] unwittingly accept the prevailing template as appropriate, right, and the proper way of doing things” (Greenwood and Hinings, 1996, p. 1027); where similar institutional forms are observed, different forms of isomorphism (competitive, or institutional) can be observed. Although both forms of isomorphism can result in mimetic (same, or similar) practices, this could be for different reasons (Greenwood and Hinings, 1996; Pauwee and Boselie, 2005; Harcourt *et al.*, 2005).

Recent developments in institutional theory (sometimes referred to as neo-institutionalism) have drawn attention to factors, other than market pressures, to explain different patterns of organizational behavior (Greenwood and Hinings, 1996; Ferner *et al.*, 2005). One such factor is the role that social forces play in organizational change, drawing attention to social structures, norms and routines that can support, or limit, change (Dacin *et al.*, 2002; Delbridge and Edwards, 2007; Ituma *et al.*, 2011). This development has drawn attention to the notion of legitimacy. In this context of this paper, legitimacy is defined as the actions of specific social actors (organizations), intended to influence, gain acceptance and approval of key stakeholders for specific actions (Harcourt *et al.*, 2005; Jain *et al.*, 2012).

Institutional theory then provides an analytical lens to explore why, how and when particular social actor(s) use their power to legitimize specific change agendas (Zucker, 1987; Inhetveen, 1999; Jonsen *et al.*, 2013). The interest amongst management scholars in power relations and the effect on organizational decision making is not new. Pettigrew’s (1973) in-depth study of organizational decision making, based on a case of a UK retailer undergoing extensive change, concluded that decision making in organizations is fundamentally a political process: “Decision-making in organizations is not merely a thought process that balances goals and means [...] rather it may be understood as a political process that balances various power vectors” (196). Pettigrew suggests that power dynamics are likely to be heightened in contexts, where the scale of the change, and degree of uncertainty, affects existing allocations of resources. In these contexts we should anticipate increased political behaviors centered around bargaining over resources, rather than behavior that focuses on problem solving, especially in situations where executive leaders and specialists are engaged in change that requires breaking free from existing patterns.

Methodological approach

This paper draws on two main sources of data. First, an overview of EC-funded Framework Programmes aimed at promoting gender equality, specifically in the field of science and technology, drawn from EC reports. Reports are one of the key deliverables of EC Framework Programmes. Second, findings from an evaluation project, one of the sub-projects completed as part of a wider EC, ESF EQUAL Programme, undertaken during the period 2007-2009. This explored the contributions and experiences of UK-based partner organizations involved in this specific programme.

Set against the ESF’s overall aim of helping people get better and fairer jobs, this specific EQUAL Programme had three main goals: promoting the reintegration and progression of women into ITEC and related roles; promote cultural change and influence policy in order to mainstream gender diversity issues, and develop innovative recruitment and progression streams (Equalitec, 2005). Partnership working was a key mobilizing structure for this programme, as with other EC-funded

programmes (Pollack and Hafner-Burton, 2000; European Commission, 2014). Each partner organization took responsibility for leading on a specific sub-project(s), these included: running career workshops and mentoring programmes for women in the ITEC labour market; championing and running “return to work” programmes for women following a career break; conducting research into effective recruitment practices, and organizing a diversity forum series aimed at bringing key players together to debate issues, and share practices, aligned to the EC’s mainstreaming agenda. The governance structure, involved regular steering group meetings attended by partner organizations. In addition to reporting on progress, the steering group meetings were intended to provide another forum to share and disseminate “best practice”.

Partner organizations on this specific ESF EQUAL Programme, were self-selected, in so far as each had voluntarily agreed to participate. There was mix of public and private sector organizations, e.g. government departments, educational institutions, professional institutions, consultancies and private sector organizations. What appeared to unite these partner organizations was their interest in identifying solutions to the declining representation of women in the ITEC labour market. It was assumed then that participating organization’s values and goals were aligned with those of the EC’s gender mainstreaming agenda.

In the evaluation project various aspects of the contribution and experiences of partnership working was explored through semi-structured interviews, with representatives from 18, out of the 24, partner organizations. The roles that these representatives held were diverse: diversity manager, diversity specialists/consultant, HR manager, policy adviser and senior academic. Specific areas explored included: reflections on their organization’s contribution, as well as that of other partners; the extent to which their own organization had drawn on the broader learning from the programme to embed cultural change (a key aspect of gender mainstreaming), and any tensions experienced with partnership working. The findings presented in the next section, are consistent with a case study approach, where the aim is “[...] understanding the dynamics present within a single setting” (Eisenhardt, 1989, p. 534).

Findings

Discourses of institutionally funded programmes aimed at gender mainstreaming

For more than 30 years the EC has invested considerable sums of resources to promote awareness of equality in the workplace and the importance of ensuring better work opportunities for women. The recent focus has been on building a more inclusive knowledge-based society, where the role of women is improved through better employment and career prospects in science and technology. To support this policy agenda, the EC has introduced a series of Framework Programmes; the more recent of these (from the mid-1990s) aimed at supporting a gender mainstreaming agenda through the “[...] systematic incorporation of gender issues throughout all government institutions and policy” (Pollack and Hafner-Burton, 2000, p. 434). The latest Framework Programme for Research and Technological Development (FP7) is the largest investment yet made by the EC aimed at building a knowledge-based society. FP7 has a budget of €50 billion for projects conducted in the period 2007-2013 (European Commission, 2011). Many of these projects relate to the gender mainstreaming agenda (European Commission, 2010).

One particular funding stream, and the focus of this paper, is the European Social Fund EQUAL Initiative. EQUAL Programmes are based on thematic areas:

employability, entrepreneurship, adaptability, and equal opportunities. To achieve the aims of EQUAL, funding is awarded on the understanding that committed partners work together towards a common goal (European Commission, 2008). This common goal was the improved participation of women in the labour market, particularly those in technical professions (European Commission, 2006b, 2008).

Despite this continuing investment, progress towards the EC's goal of improving women's participation in the knowledge society has been slow:

The goal of boosting female participation has made some progress, but the "glass ceiling" alluded to in the final evaluation of FP6 still seems to be intact. Nevertheless, FP7 has contributed to boosting women's presence in scientific research, even if the goal of 40% participation is some way from being met. Behind the data on participation rates lies the fact that women comprise only some 30% of the research base in the Member States. This means that the target will be very difficult to reach and highlights the need for initiatives at Member State level to increase female participation in research. Women are also underrepresented in certain disciplines and at the most senior levels. As younger cohorts of researchers move through the system, this should gradually improve, but should be monitored (European Commission, 2011, p. vii).

The sense of optimism in the final sentence is predicated on a notion of a "pipeline" – a notion widely discredited across a number of domains when it comes to women's equality in the workplace.

Arguably a mainstreaming agenda requires a revolutionary, as opposed to evolutionary, change approach, and to achieve the desired radical outcomes (Cockburn, 1989; Jonsen *et al.*, 2013). Yet as Pollack and Hafner-Burton (2000) acknowledge, a mainstreaming agenda is both demanding and complex, requiring new perspectives and new areas of expertise in order to challenge and change established structures, policies and procedures. They argue that despite the elaborate structures and policies that underpin the EC's Framework Programmes, there is little evidence of any fundamental (radical) re-thinking of approaches to support the overall ends/goals of Framework Programmes. Pollack and Hafner-Burton (2000) further suggest that the overall agenda continues to be strategically framed with reference to rational economic efficiency arguments, as evidenced by the continued use of a "business case" discourse, despite the documented limitations.

Yet despite the aims of Framework Programmes and the associated initiatives, outcomes consistent with a radical change approach that address "[...] the outcomes of the contest, rather than the rules of the game" Cockburn (1989, p. 215), appear lacking (Dömsch, 2006; Glover and Guerrier, 2010). This situation can perhaps be explained through recent developments in institutional theory that refer to the notion of legitimacy as a rationale for organizational behavior. Where legitimacy is perceived as a valuable commodity, those in positions of power may utilize this to justify if, when and how, to change, especially where such change may be considered radical, i.e. affecting/disrupting all parts of the organizations (Yang and Konrad, 2011).

Evaluation project findings: structures that reinforce "institutional isomorphism", not "institutional innovation"

In this Section I refers to two themes that emerged from the interviews partner organizations, which highlight tensions with partnership working as a fundamental mobilizing structure on EC-funded programmes, particularly on this ESF EQUAL Programme. These include: frustration with intra-organizational collaborative working, despite the potential for "collaborative advantage" (Dudau and McAllister,

2010), and structures and processes that reinforce “institutional isomorphism” (Pauwee and Boselie, 2005).

Tensions with ESF EQUAL Programme structures: frustrations with intra-organizational collaborative working. Despite personal commitment to this programme’s wider aims, representatives from partner organizations spoke of their frustrations with structures intended to achieve collaborative advantage (Huxham and Macdonald, 1992, in Dudau and McAllister, 2010), through supporting and encouraging intra-organizational collaborative working, which in practice did not support this goal. This was expressed by a policy adviser representing one of the government departments as:

The weakness, from our point of view was, really, we didn’t want to be driving these types of projects. We wanted to just make sure that if you had organizations, with similar remits, and they all had an interest in getting more women into the sector, or retaining women in the sector, that as much as possible they could collaborate, rather than working individually. Because then they’re all doing bits of work here and there, and not having the sort of collaborative impact that we wanted.

Another individual, representing a diversity consultancy, expressed a similar frustration:

It was a challenging project. We need to think about, for other similar projects, whether there is a way of getting the different parties to work better together. It was difficult getting information on what the different partners were doing. When I asked, I hit a nerve so I stepped back and stopped asking. It is an issue of frustration, more so than a criticism.

One plausible explanation for a lack of willingness of some partners to share information, particularly with those from consultancy organizations, could be due to concerns about how such information might be used. Even though, as mentioned earlier, it was assumed that partner organizations shared the programme’s overall aims and values, it is plausible that each partner organization had its own sub-agenda. It was clear from the interviews that participation had had to be justified on business case terms.

A related sense of frustration arose with regard to the purpose and format of steering group meetings (a common structural form). These were perceived by some as a lost opportunity for innovative thinking, which might then lead to “institutional innovation” (Inhetveen, 1999), as one policy adviser from a professional institution commented:

They didn’t make the best use of these [steering group] meetings. They were used as a reporting forum [...] they did not use them as an opportunity to push the agenda forward. It was an updating forum, rather than a building ideas forum.

Despite the assumed collaborative advantage of partnership working these experiences suggest that, unless well managed, this approach may do no more than act as awareness raising fora. Although raising awareness is important, this action on its own is unlikely to result in actions consistent with a radical change approach (Yang and Konrad, 2011).

Tensions with ESF EQUAL Programme structures: outcomes and outputs that reinforce the adoption of mimetic “best practice”. A further tension uncovered in interviews with partner organizations, was the use and effectiveness of reports as a mechanism for influencing social change. One consultant, representing one of the participating professional institutions, commented: “Too many reports and some too heavy weight. People do not read them, they haven’t got the time”. Whilst this

particular individual did not elaborate on which type of people do not have time to read these reports, insights gained from the interview with a diversity manager in a private sector organization suggests that reports from these types of programmes do not appear on the radar of influential social actors. When asked how reports from this particular programme had been used to influence change in his own organization, the response was:

There hasn't been much use [...] although now you come to mention it, one thing I can do actually is put them [reports] up, because we have just launched our diversity intranet site, and we have a tab for documentation relating to the different strands'.

In contrast, a policy adviser from a different government department commented on how useful the reports and case studies generated from these programmes were from his perspective, as these:

[...] provided some quite useful evidence, case study material, and evidence on what the issues were for women returnees, and so on [...] we [policy advisers] could then flag up that things were being disseminated [...] in that way we were helping to get the message out wider, and to industry, which is our main interest.

The reference here to "main interest" would seem consistent with recent developments in institutional theory that emphasizes the way in which legitimacy has become a driver of organizational behavior (Greenwood and Hinings, 1996; Yang and Konrad, 2011). In terms of the scope of the involvement of this specific government department this appears to have been legitimized through reference to specific short-term departmental targets; once achieved, there seemed less of a sense of responsibility for moving the agenda beyond raising awareness of the issues for women returners. One policy adviser, this time from one of the professional institutions, commented "Yes, it [programme] is successful in creating or identifying good role models, and producing good materials that encourage employers to consider these people. But as we were saying before, getting it mainstreamed, getting that next level of change to happen, is a major issue [...] look at the number of engineers, or the number of women going into engineering, I mean there are a million initiatives to try and get them interested in engineering, but none of them succeeding". Overall the sense that emerged from the evaluation findings, and one reinforced in other reports, was one of frustration with reports (a key deliverable of EC programmes) that do not offer new insights, but instead encourage the "cloning" of organizational practice (Dömsch, 2006; Royal Academy of Engineering, 2007).

Discussion: the contribution of institutional theory in explaining the lack of radical change from gender mainstreaming programmes

Despite continuing significant investment in programmes aimed at creating enhanced employment opportunities for women in the knowledge economy, the representation of women in ITEC and related occupations remains low (European Commission, 2004; DTL, 2005; Glover and Guerrier, 2010).

As Inhetveen (1999, p. 414) argues, change directed at redressing gender inequalities in society requires institutional innovation to generate "new routine-reproduced, taken-for-granted, behaviors". But as the findings and discussion above show "[...] institutional frameworks define the end, and shape the means, by which interests are determined and pursued" (Friedland and Alford, 1987, in Scott, 1987, p. 508). In the case of EC-funded programmes, partnership working remains a fundamental mobilizing structure. Through the lens of institutional theory I have exposed how

the anticipated collaborative advantage of partnership working is not guaranteed. The political behaviors of the different social actors' involved (e.g. sub-agendas, self-promotional activities, linked to reputational capital) can get in the way of more open discussion and dialogue that might then result in more innovative solutions emerging.

So instead of adopting the more risky strategy of breaking free from existing institutional norms, partner organizations engaged in this specific programme appeared to seek the security of signposting and promoting the use of mimetic practices (Greenwood and Hinings, 1996; Pauwee and Boselie, 2005; Harcourt *et al.*, 2005), legitimized through the "symbolic adoption of best practices" (Yang and Konrad, 2011, p. 13). Individuals representing government departments were found to be equally culpable of such behavior. Although these findings reinforce wider criticisms of the irrational nature of managerial decision making, particularly that of slavishly pursuing a single "one best way" of managing (Evans and Holmes, 2013), they also extend our thinking by drawing attention to the way that the discourse of "best practice" has in itself become institutionalized.

It is perhaps ironic that although enhanced innovation is one of the espoused business case benefits of a diversity management approach, there would appear to be little new (innovative) in terms of the mobilizing structures and processes utilized to progress a gender mainstreaming agenda. Experts involved in the myriad of diversity change programmes funded by the EC, have called for a radical overall of existing change management processes (see European Commission, 2006a). Yet one of the more recent EC reports, relating to the European Structural and Investment Funds' programmes, continues to promote the discourse of "best practice", particularly with respect to the implementation of the partnership principle (European Commission, 2014). In all, seven areas of good practice are set out in this latest report, including good practice cases in: involving different categories of partners; involving partners in monitoring and evaluating programmes, as well as the assessment of the implementation of partnership working. But what appears to be missing here is any reference to the role, or obligations, of partners in challenging structures that get in the way of achieving gender mainstreaming. Success factors are still defined in terms of outputs "[...] [the network] produced several key lessons reports, ran a web portal including a database on partnership experiences [...]" (European Commission, 2014, p. 5).

The political nature of organizational decision making, as already discussed, means that outputs of this nature are more likely to reinforce incremental, as opposed to radical, change. Pursuing a radical change agenda, which a gender mainstreaming agenda is, could have disastrous consequences for ambitious leaders who are keen to protect their own interests. Deviations from accepted institutional order can be costly, in terms of increased economic risk, or questionable legitimacy amongst broader society (Phillips *et al.*, 2004). The assumption then that the business case approach, reinforced through the European Union's strategy that shortages of labour, or talent, will drive business change, is something that still needs challenging (Rubery and Rafferty, 2013; Jonsen *et al.*, 2013).

In conclusion, the application of institutional theory as an analytical tool to explore the effectiveness of mobilizing structures that underpin institutionally funded change programmes aimed at a gender mainstreaming agenda, has enabled me to offer explanations as to why they do not always achieve the intended outcomes. It has exposed how these structures reinforce institutional isomorphism (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983), as opposed to encouraging institutional innovation (Inhetveen, 1999).

Even though improved innovation is one of the espoused business benefits of building a diverse workforce, those leading diversity change projects would appear to seek the comfort of tried, though not necessarily evidenced, approaches. Change consistent with a more radical approach requires challenging the archetypal patterns in the structures and processes that legitimize the adoption of mimetic “best practice” (Greenwood and Hinings, 1996). Finally, I propose three recommendations aimed at those with responsible for commissioning programmes that involve large-scale partnership working. First, consider establishing different metrics for evaluating the effectiveness of the structural forms and roles required to facilitate innovative thinking. Second, extend the scope of the “critical friend” concept (European Commission, 2014). For example, by allocating specific roles to organizations/individuals whose sole purpose is to help partners think through and break away from “patterns of locked-in loops (Jonsen *et al.*, 2013, p. 284; Reagans and McEvily, 2003) that get in the way of innovative solutions becoming mainstreamed in the respective partner organizations?”. Third, consider more robust mechanisms for filtering out partners whose behavior could be considered as gaming, i.e. participating purely to enhance reputational capital.

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